

Customer Support Escalation Procedures

Owning area: Customer_support

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Applies to: IronStore customer support operations across Europe

1. Purpose and Overview

This procedure defines how IronStore identifies, manages, and escalates customer contacts that cannot be resolved through standard frontline support. It is intended to ensure consistent decisions, timely ownership, and appropriate protection of customer, payment, product, and company information.

Escalation is required when a case involves material customer impact, operational risk, legal or regulatory considerations, reputational risk, or a resolution outside the agent's authority. Escalation does not remove ownership from the original agent unless a receiving team formally accepts the case.

The procedure applies to contacts received through email, telephone, chat, social media, marketplace messaging, and the IronStore Help Centre.

2. Scope

This procedure covers:

- Order, delivery, return, refund, payment, and product-support cases.
- Complaints involving vulnerable customers, discrimination, safety, or accessibility.
- Suspected fraud, account compromise, payment abuse, or privacy incidents.
- Product safety concerns, recalls, counterfeit allegations, and regulatory requests.
- High-value, high-volume, or executive-level complaints.
- Escalations between Customer Support, Logistics, Payments, Trust & Safety, Legal, and Product teams.

This procedure does not replace:

- The Personal Data Incident Response Plan.
 - The Product Safety and Recall Standard.
 - The Chargeback Handling Guide.
 - Country-specific requirements approved by Legal or Compliance.
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3. Policy Statement

IronStore support cases must be resolved at the lowest appropriate level, using approved tools and decision limits. Escalations must be based on documented facts rather than customer status, personal preference, or pressure from a third party.

Agents must:

- Record all material facts in **Zendesk** before escalating.
- Use the correct escalation category and priority.
- Avoid promising an outcome that requires another team's approval.
- Provide the customer with a realistic next-update time.
- Protect personal data by using approved internal systems only.
- Continue monitoring the case until ownership is accepted or resolution is confirmed.

No employee may disclose internal investigation details, fraud rules, warehouse controls, security information, or another customer's data.

4. Standard Escalation Procedure

4.1 Initial assessment

The assigned agent must complete the following checks:

1. Confirm the customer's identity using the approved verification steps.
2. Review the full contact history, order record, payment status, and delivery events.
3. Check for duplicate tickets, open complaints, chargebacks, or previous escalations.
4. Identify the customer's country, applicable language, currency, and service terms.
5. Determine whether the case is routine, priority, urgent, or critical.
6. Record the reason for escalation in Zendesk using the relevant macro.

If information is missing, the agent should request it before escalating unless delay could increase customer or business risk.

4.2 Escalation record requirements

Every escalation must include:

- Order number, customer ID, and relevant ticket links.
- A short factual summary of the issue.
- Actions already taken and their outcomes.

- The requested decision or assistance.
- Applicable deadline or customer commitment.
- Financial value, if relevant.
- Screenshots, carrier events, payment references, or other evidence.
- Any known legal, safety, media, or executive involvement.

Do not copy full payment card numbers, passwords, identity documents, or unnecessary personal information into ticket notes.

4.3 Priority levels

| Priority | Use when | Acknowledge | Target first action |

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| **P1 – Critical** | Safety risk, active data-security concern, major outage, or widespread customer impact | 15 minutes | 1 hour |

| **P2 – Urgent** | Significant financial loss, vulnerable customer risk, executive complaint, or likely regulatory breach | 1 hour | 4 hours |

| **P3 – High** | Repeated failed resolution, high-value order, serious delivery or payment dispute | 4 business hours | 1 business day |

| **P4 – Standard** | Specialist review required without immediate material risk | 1 business day | 3 business days |

Service targets apply during the receiving team's operating hours. P1 and P2 cases are monitored outside normal hours through the on-call rota.

5. Escalation Categories and Routing

5.1 Order, delivery, and warehouse issues

Escalate to **Logistics Operations** when:

- A parcel is missing after the carrier investigation window.
- Tracking shows delivery, but the customer disputes receipt.
- A shipment is held by customs or repeatedly misrouted.
- A warehouse error affects multiple orders or a promised delivery date.
- A replacement cannot be issued through the standard workflow.

The agent must include the carrier, tracking number, delivery address at country and city level, last scan, and promised resolution date. Address details must not be repeated in unprotected email or external chat.

Orders above **€500**, or orders with more than two failed delivery attempts, require a P3 escalation unless a P1 or P2 condition applies.

5.2 Refunds, payments, and chargebacks

Escalate to **Payments Operations** when:

- A refund is overdue by more than five business days after approval.
- The payment was captured but the order was cancelled.
- A duplicate charge is confirmed or reasonably suspected.
- A chargeback notice is received.
- The payment provider reports a technical or compliance hold.

Agents may approve refunds only within their role limit and the **Refund Authority Matrix CS-FIN-006**. Refunds above **€250**, goodwill credits above **€75**, or exceptions to published return terms require Team Lead approval. Amounts above **€1,000** require Payments Operations approval and Finance notification.

Do not advise a customer to withdraw a chargeback before the case has been reviewed by Payments Operations.

5.3 Fraud and account security

Escalate immediately to **Trust & Safety** when there is evidence of:

- Account takeover or unauthorised password or email changes.
- Unrecognised orders, payment methods, or delivery addresses.
- Multiple accounts using suspicious vouchers or referral credits.
- Resale, bot activity, coupon abuse, or organised returns fraud.
- Threats to expose customer or employee information.

Use the **Fraud Escalation** form in Zendesk. Do not accuse the customer of fraud or disclose detection criteria. Apply an account security hold only when authorised by Trust & Safety or under the documented emergency playbook.

Suspected personal data breaches must also be reported through **Security Hub** within 30 minutes. Customer Support must not independently investigate or delete evidence.

5.4 Product safety and quality

Escalate to **Product Compliance** as P1 or P2 when a customer reports:

- Fire, smoke, electric shock, explosion, serious injury, or hospitalisation.
- A product defect that could cause injury or property damage.
- Suspected counterfeit, unsafe, or incorrectly labelled goods.
- A possible recall or repeated safety issue involving the same product.

Capture the product name, SKU, batch or serial number, purchase date, customer description, and photographs if voluntarily provided. Tell the customer to stop using the product when appropriate, without diagnosing the fault. Do not provide technical repair instructions unless approved by Product Compliance.

5.5 Complaints, legal, and regulatory matters

Escalate to **Customer Advocacy** when:

- The customer has made two unsuccessful contacts about the same issue.
- The customer alleges discrimination, harassment, or unreasonable treatment.
- A formal complaint is requested.
- The customer references a regulator, court, solicitor, journalist, or elected representative.
- The requested remedy exceeds normal policy and may create a precedent.

Route formal legal notices, data-subject rights concerns, consumer authority requests, and threats of litigation to **Legal & Compliance**. Use the customer's country queue and preserve the original wording. Do not interpret legislation or commit to a legal position.

Complaints involving a vulnerable customer, self-harm reference, or immediate personal danger must be escalated to the Duty Manager. Emergency services should be contacted only where policy and local law permit, or where there is an immediate and credible threat.

5.6 Public and executive complaints

Social media cases should be moved to a private channel without requesting public disclosure of order details. Escalate to **Customer Advocacy** if the post alleges safety, discrimination, privacy loss, widespread failure, or employee misconduct.

Cases involving the CEO, executive leadership, investor relations, a government office, or a recognised media organisation must be tagged **Executive Review**. The agent should acknowledge receipt, avoid speculation, and provide the approved next-update time.

6. Handover, Communication, and Closure

The receiving team must accept or reject an escalation in Zendesk within the applicable acknowledgement target. A rejection must state the missing information or correct destination.

The original agent remains the customer-facing owner unless:

- The receiving team assigns a named case owner.
- The Duty Manager transfers ownership.
- Legal, Security, or Trust & Safety requires restricted communication.

Customer updates must be sent at least:

- Every one business day for P1 and P2 cases.
- Every two business days for P3 cases.
- At each agreed milestone for P4 cases.

If no new information is available, the update should state that the investigation remains open and provide the next review date. Never use “resolved” merely because an escalation was submitted.

A case may be closed when the approved action is complete, the customer has been informed, and all internal notes and evidence are recorded. P1 and P2 cases require a closure note identifying root cause, customer impact, corrective action, and any follow-up owner.

7. Roles and Responsibilities

- **Support Agent:** Verify, document, classify, escalate, and maintain customer communication.
 - **Team Lead:** Approve exceptions within authority, review P2/P3 cases, and support difficult contacts.
 - **Duty Manager:** Own P1 incidents, out-of-hours decisions, and cross-functional coordination.
 - **Customer Advocacy:** Manage formal complaints, executive contacts, and repeated service failures.
 - **Payments Operations:** Review payment exceptions, refunds, chargebacks, and financial controls.
 - **Trust & Safety:** Investigate fraud, account compromise, abuse, and suspicious activity.
 - **Product Compliance:** Assess product safety, recalls, and regulatory product concerns.
 - **Legal & Compliance:** Advise on legal notices, regulatory matters, privacy rights, and precedent-setting remedies.
 - **Knowledge Management:** Maintain macros, decision trees, and quarterly procedure reviews.
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8. Related Documents and References

- **CS-POL-003:** Customer Contact and Verification Standard
 - **CS-FIN-006:** Refund Authority Matrix
 - **LOG-STD-009:** Missing Parcel and Carrier Investigation Procedure
 - **TS-POL-004:** Account Security and Fraud Escalation Playbook
 - **PC-STD-002:** Product Safety and Recall Standard
 - **SEC-IRP-001:** Personal Data Incident Response Plan
 - **LEG-GDE-005:** Consumer Complaints and Regulatory Correspondence Guide
 - **Zendesk:** Escalation macros, priority fields, and internal routing groups
 - **Security Hub:** Security and privacy incident reporting portal
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9. Revision History

- **August 2026 – Version 3.2:** Added P1/P2 response targets, updated refund approval thresholds, and clarified product safety routing.
- **February 2026 – Version 3.1:** Added executive complaint handling and Security Hub reporting requirement.

- **September 2025 – Version 3.0:** Consolidated country escalation procedures and introduced standard Zendesk escalation fields.